

CAVALRY AND THE INFANTRY SQUARE

THE BATTLE OF WATERLOO

Through the 18th and early 19th centuries, European warfare centred around the use of rigidly disciplined infantry armed with smoothbore flintlock muskets and bayonets. This style of fighting reached its climax at Waterloo on 18 June 1815, when superior French artillery and cavalry failed to crack the Duke of Wellington's steady foot soldiers.

Waterloo was the last battle of the Napoleonic Wars. On 18 June, Wellington drew up his forces in a defensive position on a ridge, intending to hold off Napoleon's 70,000-strong army until Britain's allies, the Prussians, could reach the battlefield and tip the balance decisively against the French.

Wellington fortified a chateau and farmhouse in the front of his position as strongpoints to delay the French attack, but he knew his eventual success or failure would depend on the firmness of his infantry fighting in an open field. The infantry were strictly trained to march in columns, deploy in lines, and fire in volleys. The great majority were equipped with inaccurate but reliable flintlock muskets. Additionally, British riflemen, armed with the effective Baker rifle, could fight as skirmishers in loose formation or in line.

Napoleon opened the battle with a bombardment by the heavy cannon parked at the rear of his position. While fighting raged around the chateau and farm, the French launched a corps-strength infantry attack on the centre of the British line. At first skirmishing troops, the *voltigeurs*, swarmed forward to snipe at Wellington's men, who were drawn up in formation two lines deep. The main body of French troops then advanced in large close-packed columns with bayonets fixed. Each British soldier could fire three rounds a minute, and with two lines firing alternate volleys, the infantry poured six volleys a minute into the dense French ranks. As field artillery joined in, sweeping the columns with canister,

grapeshot, and shrapnel, the French were halted and driven back, sustaining heavy casualties.

HOLDING THE SQUARE

In the afternoon, around 4:00pm, Wellington's infantry were exposed to repeated attacks by French cavalry. Napoleon's horsemen ranged from heavily armoured cuirassiers to lighter dragoons, chasseurs and hussars, and a body of Polish lancers. The standard infantry response to a cavalry charge was to form squares. The square's "walls" consisted of soldiers three or four lines deep. The bayonets of the front line, bristling outward, held the enemy horses at bay on all four sides while the men further inside the square fired at the cavalry. The lancers' weapons were long enough to reach into the square, but the real threat lay in artillery. In the late afternoon, after taking the fortified farm, the French moved their cannon forward to blast at the infantry squares. Once savaged by shot or shell, a square could be penetrated by cavalry, who cut down the foot soldiers with their swords.

Wellington later commented that he was "never as near being beat" as at Waterloo. But ultimately his line held both against the cavalry charges and a final attack by the infantry of Napoleon's elite Imperial Guard. As the Prussians, led by Count von Blücher, arrived on the French flank, Wellington ordered a general advance. The French were driven from the field and Napoleon's remarkable military career was finally brought to an end.

